



ROAD TO SUCCESS: Ahmedabad-Bhuj national highway (above); Bhuria in front of his factory (below)



RISING FROM RUINS

Kutch has risen like a phoenix from the ruins of the 2001 earthquake, turning an arid marshland into a thriving industrial district with leading corporate houses investing in its future

■ By Uday Mahurkar in Bhuj

As one crosses the Surajbari bridge, gateway to Kutch from Gujarat, the skyline comes as a surprise to anyone who is familiar with the area. Instead of a sparsely populated, arid landscape, it now boasts of a series of modern factories churning out the best known brands in the country. This was once the world's largest marshy desert, cut off from the rest of the country. But the killer quake of January 2001 that turned parts of Kutch into ruins, changed all that. Help poured in from all parts of the world and the five-year excise and sales exemptions lured the best industries to Kutch. The resilience of the locals and a private-public partnership model of development and rehabilitation helped in rapid resurrection of the area. The new Kutch is to be seen to be believed, with a mas-

sive economic boom and changing lifestyle of the people of the district.

The change is most visible in Adani Port at Mundra, a private sector enterprise. Besides the port, the Adani Group is setting up a multi-sector SEZ and a 4,000 MW power plant investing around Rs 25,000 crore while the Tatas are also setting up a 4,000 MW power plant. The Adanis have already set up a private airstrip here. In four years, Kutch district will be the largest manufacturer of cement in the country. In power generation, it will occupy the number one spot in four years generating 7,000 MW. "Kutch has emerged as the biggest manufacturer of saw pipes in Asia, thanks to a series of manufacturing units that have come up in the past five years," says Rasik Mamtara of the Federation of Kutch Industries Association.

The district has seen an investment

of over Rs 40,000 crore in five years in the form of 188 new units in every industrial sphere giving direct employment to 18,000 people, a large number of them locals, and indirect employment to another 25,000 people. Amongst those which have pitched tents in Kutch are big brands like LG, Hindustan Lever, Parle, Ajanta and Euro Tiles. Power generation through windmills is yet another sunrise industry that is fast developing in Kutch.

It will see investment worth another Rs 60,000 crore in the next five years. Admits Kirti Khatri, editor of Kutch's largest newspaper, *Kutchmitra*: "Kutch has broken away from centuries-old seclusion to become a shining star of the mainstream". Adds Ashok Bhuria, a Kutchi NRI businessman based for years in the UK, who set up an advanced window and door manufacturing unit on Bhuj's outskirts: "I had a dream of